

How the Unconscious mind shapes human behavior

By Ethan kennedy

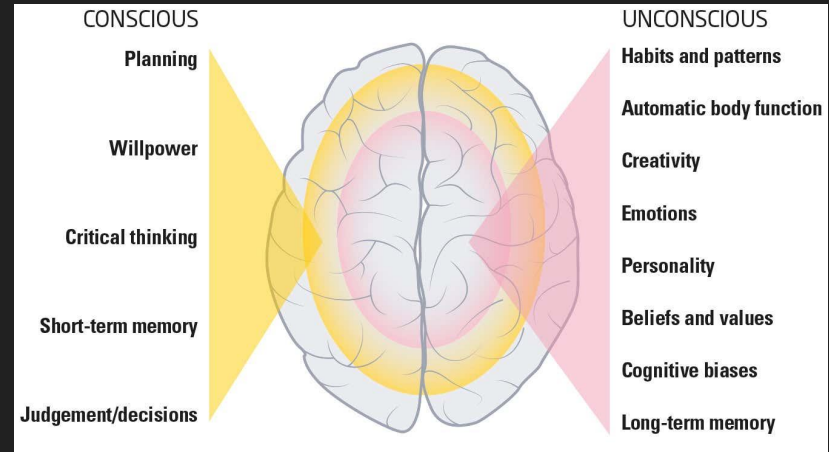
Introduction

Thesis statement:

Despite the debate over its credibility and accountability, the unconscious mind significantly influences behaviors, emotions, and social dynamics. Evidence from culture, psychology, and neuroscience shows how the unconscious mind processes shape the way we experience and respond to the world.

Overview:

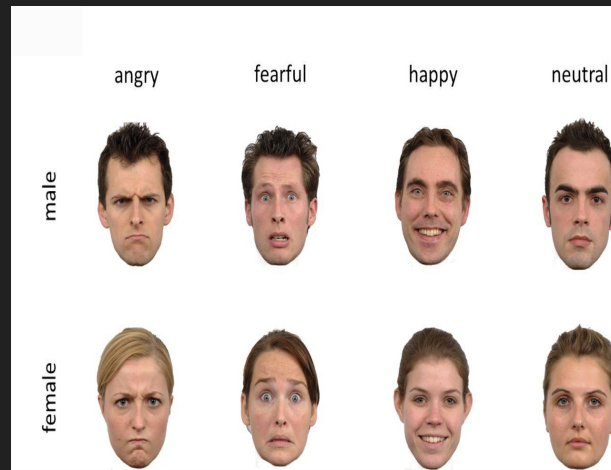
A lot of what we think, do, or feel happens without us realizing it. The unconscious mind takes in cues from surroundings. These cues can impact how we feel, act, and treat others, even if we aren't consciously aware of them. Whether its a quick emotional reaction or a subtle bias, the unconscious plays a role in our day to day lives



Caroline Williams, "Lifting the Lid on the Unconscious," *New Scientist*, no. 3188 (August 25, 2018), <https://www.newscientist.com/article/mg23931880-400-lifting-the-lid-on-the-unconscious/>.

Reacting and not knowing why

- We often do and feel things before we realize why.
- Two researchers Bargh and Morsella found that our environment can trigger emotional reactions before conscious awareness.
- A simple facial expression, tone of voice, posture, etc can shift your mood without you realizing it at first.
- These ideas show that our actions and feelings don't always come from conscious thinking and that instead they are automatic processes the are reacting or steer for us.

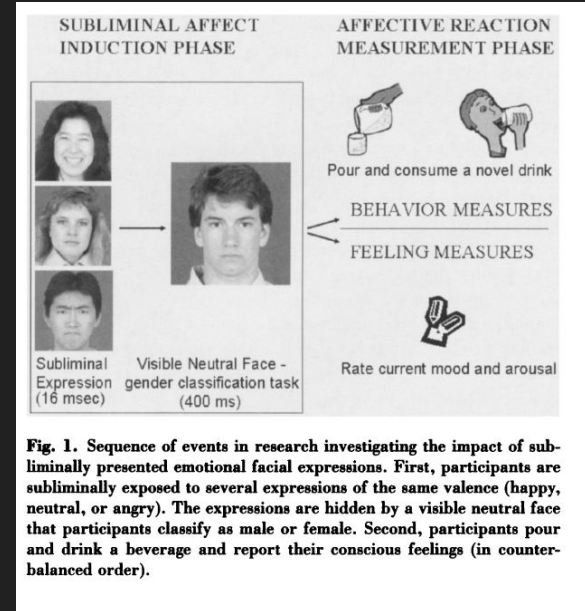


Moshe Bar, "Cognitive Neuroscience of the Unconscious: A Reappraisal," *bioRxiv* (2018), <https://www.biorxiv.org/content/10.1101/479899v1.full>.

Lemon drink experiment

-The tiniest flash of emotion from someone or something can change what we like or how much we enjoy

Winkleman and berridge experiment:
People were exposed to different emotional faces such as happy, neutral, or angry so fast that they didn't consciously realize that it changed their emotion. They then drank a sour beverage and those who saw happy faces drank more than those who saw angry faces even though they didn't report consciously feeling different.



Winkielman, Piotr, and Kent C. Berridge. "Unconscious Emotion." *Current Directions in Psychological Science* 13, no. 3 (2004): 120-24.

Unconscious bias

- People might be in favor or against others based on their race, sex, or age without consciously meaning to. Some of these reactions you have are automatic meaning they don't come from conscious hate and also they can be caused from life experiences, culture, or media.
- Tetlock did a study on whether people were comfortable with accusing or punishing someone based off their unconscious biases when they didn't mean to be bias in the first place.
- The reason unconscious bias matters is because it can affect your ability to get a job, change policing actions, or even change friendships. You may think you are being fair but your brain might've already made a judgement without your awareness.



Gregory Ferenstein, "How Today's Tech Will Shape Tomorrow's Job Interview," *TechCrunch*, June 3, 2015, <https://techcrunch.com/2015/06/03/how-todays-tech-will-shape-tomorrows-job-interview/>

Final thoughts

We think of ourselves as thoughtful, cautious, and in control, however, research shows that hidden processes influence us all the time.

understanding our unconscious can help make better choices on interactions with others, now there are things you can't control such as mood, but if we want to be more self-aware and treat people more fairly, we have to look at the parts ourselves we usually ignore.



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